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Leather-clad CA Dem steps down as Jewish Caucus co-chair after Israel 'genocide' claim

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Author: Dana Sauchelli | Section: Us News | 426 Words
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The California state senator who called Israel's war in Gaza "genocide" has stepped down as co-chair of the Legislature's Jewish Caucus after fierce backlash from Jewish leaders around his comments.

State Sen. Scott Wiener announced the move Thursday morning and said he would vacate the post on February. 15, J. The Jewish News of Northern California reported.

"Last fall, with a demanding congressional campaign looming, I suggested stepping down but was asked to stay to provide continuity of leadership during a difficult time for the Jewish community," Wiener said in the statement to J.

Weiner stepped down after backlash from Jewish leaders about his war in Gaza comments. Getty Images for Macy's

"Now, my campaign is accelerating, and my recent statements on Israel and Gaza have led to significant controversy in the Jewish community. The time to transition has arrived."

The abrupt resignation came after Wiener — who is eyeing Rep. Nancy Pelosi's soon-to-be-vacated US House seat — caved to an anti-Israel crowd at a congressional candidate forum earlier this month.

"For years, I've condemned Netanyahu and his extremist government and the devastation they've inflicted on Gaza. It's why I've been clear I won't support U.S. funding for the destruction of Palestinian communities. I've stopped short of calling it genocide, but I can't anymore," he wrote on X following the event coverage.

Co-chair of the caucus, Jesse Gabriel, said Weiner made the right call by removing himself. Getty Images for Equality California

In the post, he included a video explaining his position where he said, "to me the Israeli government has tried to destroy Gaza and to push Palestinians out and that qualifies as genocide."

Outrage over his post led to petitions and letter-writing campaigns that circulated online, calling for his stepping-down and demanding that the caucus stand up, J. reported.

Wiener was elected to the state senate's Jewish Caucus in 2020 and became co-chair in 2023, according to J.

His co-chair of the caucus, Jesse Gabriel (D-Encino), said that Wiener made the right call by removing himself.

"I think it's important for people to understand that Sen. Wiener made this statement in his capacity as a candidate for Congress in San Francisco, and not as chair of the caucus, and that there are many of our members that disagree with him, many who vehemently disagree with him on the issue," Gabriel said, according to J.

"Ultimately, I think he made the right decision."

Wiener, who is gay, has been a regular at San Francisco's Folsom Street Fair, where he's been spotted wearing a leather vest and tie, and has described himself as a staunch advocate for drag culture.

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